

"Colonization"

Ques - 1. Explain how the British colonial agricultural system had significantly altered the land, labor, agriculture and infrastructural pattern of colonized Africa.

Answer: Colonialism was a system of extracting wealth from the continent; agricultural products were part of this wealth. Colonial powers normally emphasised production which met their needs and tastes, not the needs of the local communities which affects local or colonized agricultural system.

From the outset we should point out that pre-mercantilist Africa was self-sufficient in food production and was neither inferior nor weaker than the rest of the Ancient World. Food production was the primary goal of agriculture. Sophisticated techniques had evolved which were suited to the needs of the people and their fragile environment and which helped them cope with cyclical droughts and crop failures due to other causes. Adequate food security and self-reliance were common before European colonization. Methods had been developed for storage of surpluses and complex patterns of trade had been developed around food availability.

The British colonial agricultural system had also a profound and lasting impact on Africa, reshaping land use, labor patterns, agricultural production, and infrastructure in ways that benefited the colonial economy but often harmed local communities. Here's how these areas were altered:

Land: Before the African colonization, all countries of Africa was self sufficient. The land of Africa was fertile and people used to produce food crop such as maize, lentil etc for the nutrition. After colonization, Europe forced Africa to cultivate cash crop instead of food crop. Cash crop such as rubber, cocoa, tea, coffee etc were produced forcefully by the African labor for the own need of Europe. Most of the arable land were therefore occupied to produce to cash crop. Land for producing food crops were about to be destroyed.

Labor: Before colonization, African labor used to produce food crops on their own land. After colonization, peasants who wanted to produce food crop instead of cash crop were forced to cultivate cash chop in their own land or on the land forcefully taken by the European or settlers. Some of labors were migrated to other place in the need of producing cash chop. Self sufficient peasants became labor for producing carsh crop. 100 million of men and women were involved in producing cash crop.

Agriculture/food: Since affer colonization Africa was dependent on cultivating cash crop, more than half of the arable used to produce cash crop, food crop for the locals became insufficient. Before the colonization, African community had a diversity of producing food crop. As there started a scarcity of food crops after colonization, people need to import their essential food crop. Monocropping culture destroyed the traditional agricultural pattern. Therefore, agricultural pattern changed and african countries became food importing economy.



Infrastructure: The Europeans constructed many infrastructures with a view to the easy collection of raw materials and cash crops. For example, a railway constructed from Senegal to Mali through the groundnut field to collect groundnut easily and the railway ended up at the coastal point. Similarly, in India, European constructed railway to collect cotton.

After colonization, European forced the African peasants to produce cash crop for their own benefit. There was a phenomenon of low price extraction and high price selling. For example, in 1930's, peanuts bought by marketing board from West African peasants were sold in Britain at more than seven times what the peasants received.

In summury, the British colonial agricultural system altered African's land use, labor pattern, agricultural production and infrastructure, favoring the colonial economy while undermining local communities and traditional ways of life. These changes contributed to the long lasting socio-economic and environmental challenges faced by many African nations post-independence.

Ques - 2. Explain how the post colonial states in Africa have continued to pursue policies which promoted cash crop over food crop.

Answer: Most of the present-day agricultural patterns in Africa have their origins in the colonial era. These patterns (especially cash crop plantations) were established to meet the needs of Europe. The post-colonial governments of the 1960s inherited those agricultural patterns and structures and continued their management.

African people made great sacrifices to get their independence from 1955 to 1965. But even if some kind of political change has occurred, the economic structures remained almost untouched, especially the structures of cash crops economy with cocoa and oil palm plantations in the forest zone, cotton and groundnuts in the Savana of West Africa, and coffee, tea, sisal and cotton in East Africa. For example, Senegal continued to export groundnuts which occupied 55 percent of its arable land in 1976 and provided 50 percent of its foreign exchange in 1977. In 1977, half of Ghana's arable land was planted with cocoa trees. A similar proportion of arable lands in Kenya was devoted to coffee and tea. The concentration on a limited number of crops is a characteristic of African agriculture.

In 1984, nine countries in Africa were dependent on just one crop for over 70percent of their income. Over 70% of Burundi's export earnings came from coffee, which provided over 70% of Rwanda's earnings and almost 70% of Ethiopia's. Other nations over 50% reliant on one single crop included Mauritius (sugar), Uganda (coffee), Chad (cotton), Sudan (cotton), Ghana (cocoa), Kenya (coffee) and Mali (cotton).

That is, after gaining independence, many African states continued to prioritize the cultivation of cash crops over food crops, often due to a combination of historical legacies, economic



pressures, and global market dynamics. Let's draw examples from Kenya and socialist Tanzania.

Kenya: In Kenya, farmers who grow cash crops get more support, such as loans, advice on pesticides and fertilisers, and help with marketing, than those who grow food crops. Food crop farmers often say their boards are slow and inefficient compared to the Kenya Coffee Board.

Tanzania: In Tanzania, although the country promotes self-reliance and peasant farming, in 1983 the government cut the agriculture budget by 3.5% compared to the previous five-year plan. Most of the money (80%) went to large-scale farms that rely on foreign supplies, while only 2% was spent on helping small peasant farmers.

In Tanzania, loans from the Rural Development Bank to small farmers growing food dropped from 6.7% in 1971–72 to just 1% in 1979–80. Meanwhile, loans to government-owned companies rose from 6.4% to 70.7%. In 1978–79, most of the money for farming inputs (61%) went to tobacco, a cash crop that harms the environment by depleting soil and causing deforestation. This shows that, despite its support for peasant farming, Tanzania moved away from its original policy.

These examples show that Africa's food problems are mostly caused by poor policies. Focusing too much on cash crops hasn't solved the issue—in fact, it has made it worse.

Ques - 3. What is the impact of such policies on the economy and land pattern of the post independent African countries?

Answer: Growing demand from industries in Europe and North America drove exponential growth in export crops at the expense of food security. In Western Africa, exports to Britain and France doubled five times and three times, respectively, over a 70-year period (1870 to 1940). The area dedicated to export crops in SSA increased by 56% during the 1800s and a further 136% from 1900 to 1960. This increase was initially fuelled by high commodity prices, but after 1880 it was driven by the need to offset the impact of declining prices and the onset of WWI. Hence, the growth in export crop production was driven by colonial demand rather than farmers responding to market opportunities. This subsection summarizes six inter-related impacts of this expansion that undermined food security. The policies of prioritizing cash crops over food crops in post-independence African countries have had significant and long-lasting impacts on both their economies and land patterns. The impacts can be discussed as below.

1. Price Decline: All countries of Africa started to grow their cash crop cultivation at the same time. Therefore the world market was flooded by over supply of cash crop. Whereas, the demand for these cash crop was relatively smaller. Therefore, there was surplus in the world market. As a result, price of cash crop declines.

2. Deterioration in Terms of Trade: Despite the priorities the governments give to cash crops, their prices continued to fall over time in comparison to the prices of manufactured goods. In



1960, three tons of bananas could buy a tractor. In 1970, that same tractor costs the equivalent of eleven tons of bananas. 25 tons of exported rubber an African country could import six tractors in 1960. In 1975 it could import only 2 tractors. This deterioration of the terms of trade may well continue.

3. Decline In Foreign Earnings: As price of cash crop decreased and as African was dependent on cash crop, the foreign earnings declined. In 1970 to 1980 drought hit in Africa and cash crop cultivation destroyed. It also resulted in decline in foreign currency earnings. In WWII, the total loss of foreign earning exceeded all foreign investment, fund, loan, grants.

4. Import/debt: As African imports food crop by using this foreign currency, declining in foreign earnings results in scarcity of food crop. Declining in food supply increased importing food which led in taking foreign loans/debt. By 1984 1 in 4 Africans are fed by impor. External debt reached 130 billion.

5. Loss and replacement of traditional sources of nutrition: Land clearance and mono-cropping destroyed opportunities for grazing, hunting, fishing, and growing nutritious pulses and vegetables. Nutrition and livestock productivity declined and income to supplement diets was lost. Cassava and dent maize replaced more nutritious staples due to their higher calorific content, faster growth, and lower labour requirements. Dent maize was preferred for export as it had higher yields and larger kernels and was more suitable for mechanized milling. Serious health issues arose when maize became the primary staple, as it is low in essential amino acids and associated with diarrhoea, dementia, dermatitis, and cognitive deficiencies. Malnutrition has long-term impacts on physical development and the ability to pursue education and careers and is therefore an impediment to the prosperity of individuals and households. Food shortages and poor nutrition continued to increase during the 1920s and the calorie intake dropped to starvation level. In response, maize production was further encouraged, which increased the calorie intake but made malnutrition endemic.

6. Inequality within communities: The wealthy and powerful local elite focused on achieving colonial pursuits rather than community prosperity. In the peasant colonies, the increased demand for export crops, such as cocoa in Ghana, forced to 'sell' land to wealthy and influential farmers from neighbouring areas, widening the inequality experienced by local farmers and migrant workers. The cash-advance crop mortgage system also exacerbated inequality. This system lent money to small-scale farmers unable to fund export production. Interest rates varied but were typically 50-100% for cocoa, and up to 200% on the savanna. Advances were based on crop estimates and were to be repaid at harvest, regardless of the outcome. Considering the vagaries of late rains, locusts, price variability, disease, and personal calamity, harvests regularly fell short of estimates, Farmers had to borrow more money at escalating rates, creating a vicious circle of borrowing and debt re-payments. Merchant manipulation of scales, transport prices and chiefs' timing of tax payments are further examples of how the elites widened inequality and created dependency.

